

The Facts on Fat

Why Do We Need Fat in Our Diet?

Fat is an essential nutrient needed for good health. It is common for people experiencing an eating disorder to have the belief that “all fat is bad” or “fat makes you gain weight”. Research shows that people with eating disorders often lack essential fatty acids and vitamin D—both of which are nutrients commonly provided by dietary fat.



Fat is an important part of a balanced diet because:

- *When stored in the body, fat plays an important role as a energy store which the body can use if energy is required.*
- *It provides 2 essential fatty acids (linoleic acid and alpha-linoleic acid) which our bodies cannot manufacture on their own.*
- *It provides insulation and protection for internal organs and reproductive organs.*
- *It helps absorb fat soluble vitamins (vitamins A, D, E and K) and phytochemicals like beta-carotene and lycopene.*
- *It provides fatty acids required for making hormones, brain cells and healthy skin.*
- *It supports the release of hormones during digestion that help you feel full.*
- *It adds flavour and texture to foods.*
- *It assists in slowing down the rate at which your stomach empties, thus leaving you more satisfied for longer.*
- *For women, eating too little fat can lead to low body fat, which may impact menstruation and reproductive health.*

What are the Different Types of Fats

Saturated fats: these fats tend to be solid at room temperature and are found mainly in animal foods (e.g. butter, cream, meats, cheese, milk) but also include palm oil and coconut oil.

Mono unsaturated fats: these fats are found predominantly in olives, olive oil, canola oil, avocados, peanuts and most other nuts. All oils contain some monounsaturated fats as do meat, chicken, eggs and fish.

Polyunsaturated fats: these fats are extracted from seeds such as sunflower, safflower, soy beans, sesame and grape seed to make cooking oils.

Omega-3 fats: these fats are a sub-group of polyunsaturated fats with a slightly different structure. Fish (especially oily fish like salmon, tuna and sardines) and seafood contain high levels of 2 omega-3 fats called EPA and DHA.

Trans fats: these fats are structurally the same as unsaturated fats but in the body, behave the same as saturated fats. They occur naturally in butter, milk, beef and lamb.

Cholesterol: cholesterol is a waxy, fat-like compound found in the blood and is different from fat. It is an essential part of cell membranes and is used to create hormones and vitamin D.



Five Tips to Make Sure You're Meeting Your Fat Requirements

1. Add a fat based spread (e.g. butter, margarine, peanut butter, avocado, hummus, mayonnaise) anytime you are having toast/bread/wrap/sandwich.
2. Use a cooking oil such as olive oil, peanut oil or vegetable oil when cooking a meal for lunch or dinner, or as part of salad dressing.
3. Include at least 3 serves of full fat calcium-rich foods everyday (e.g. cheese, yoghurt, milk or calcium-fortified soy alternatives of these).
4. Add nuts, seeds and/or olives to your lunch and dinner (e.g. add to a salad, stir-fry, pasta dish).
5. Fats come from many different foods, including dairy, meat, chicken, fish, and fun foods. Eating a variety of foods helps ensure that you are getting different types of nutrients and the healthy fats your body needs.

